habitat on Earth, some are more fragile than others, but each faces different threats, whether anthropogenic (human-made) or from natural causes, or both, and many are critically endangered.

Habitats have, of course, always been affected by destructive natural events. Every year, lightning strikes trigger large grassland and forest fires. Hurricanes and rivers in flood can wreak havoc. Storm surges may produce inundations of the sea, turning freshwater wetlands saline. About 65 million years ago, the Chicxulub meteor impact in Mexico produced a dust cloud so great that it severely reduced the amount of sunlight reaching Earth's surface. Plants struggled to photosynthesize, and many animals, including the dinosaurs, became extinct.

Nor is human influence an exclusively recent issue. Throughout history, people have modified their environment. Deforestation, for example, is not a new problem. In Europe, the clearance of forests for agriculture and construction began thousands of years ago, and a similar pattern followed in North America.

However, the impact of modern-day humans on the environment is unprecedented. In the past 200 years, the human population has exploded. This has fueled the rapid growth of cities, the development of large-scale industry based on the extraction of fossil fuels and raw materials, a growing agricultural demand to feed more people, and conflict and war. All these factors have taken their toll on the natural world.